

SHREWS

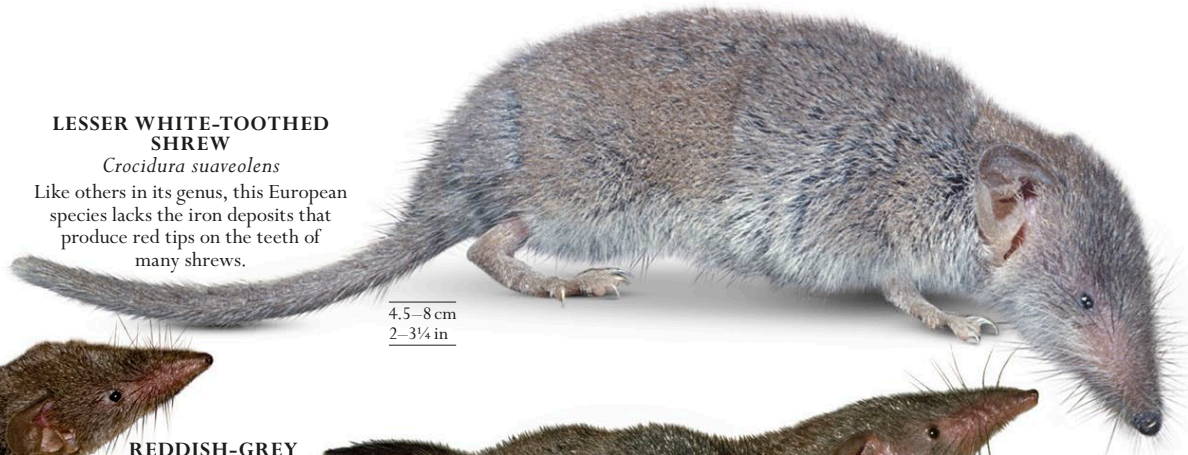
With a pointed snout, velvety fur, a long tail, and sharp, simple teeth, members of the Soricidae are largely insectivorous, but also eat seeds, fruits, and carrion. Mostly terrestrial, they are highly active, needing to eat at least 80 per cent of their own body weight daily. They have poor vision, but excellent senses of hearing and smell, and use echolocation to find their way around.

LESSER WHITE-TOOTHED SHREW

Crocidura suaveolens

Like others in its genus, this European species lacks the iron deposits that produce red tips on the teeth of many shrews.

4.5–8 cm
2–3¼ in



6.5–9.5 cm
2½–3¾ in

REDDISH-GREY SHREW

Crocidura cyanea

Males of this southern African forest shrew use a strong musky scent to mark their territories.

9–16 cm
3½–6½ in



HOUSE SHREW

Suncus murinus

Native to S. Asia but introduced elsewhere in Asia and Africa, this adaptable, uniformly grey-brown shrew is often associated with human habitation.



3.5–5 cm
1½–2 in

pale feet

9–11.5 cm
3½–4¾ in



NORTHERN SHORT-TAILED SHREW

Blarina brevicaudus

This large and venomous N. American species usually forages in tunnels or under leaf litter or snow, rather than above ground.

CRAWFORD'S GREY SHREW

Notiosorex crawfordi

From arid parts of N. America, this shrew can survive without water. To conserve fluid, it produces highly concentrated urine.

5.5–8 cm
2¼–3¼ in

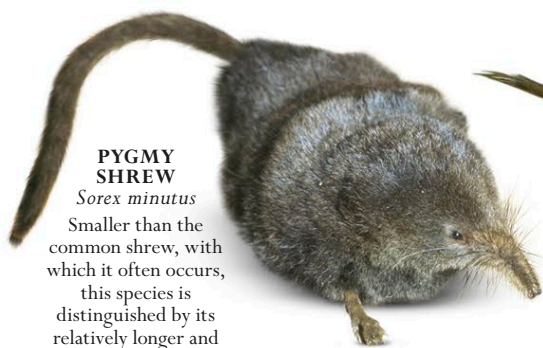


COMMON SHREW

Sorex araneus

The most common shrew in N. Europe, it is active day and night throughout the year, searching for food.

4–6.5 cm
1½–2½ in



PYGMY SHREW

Sorex minutus

Smaller than the common shrew, with which it often occurs, this species is distinguished by its relatively longer and hairier tail.

short, dense, velvety fur

ALPINE SHREW

Sorex alpinus

The tail of this dark C. European shrew is as long as its head and body. It aids balance when climbing trees.

ETRUSCAN SHREW

Suncus etruscus

One of the smallest living mammals, weighing only 2 g (1/16 oz), this shrew occurs in S. Europe and the Middle East, with closely related forms in Asia.

6–7.5 cm
2¼–3 in



5–7 cm
2–2¾ in



NORTH AMERICAN LEAST SHREW

Cryptotis parvus

A ferocious hunter, this species tackles a variety of prey. It also bites the tail of lizards, which when shed provides an easy meal.

EURASIAN WATER SHREW

Neomys fodiens

The stiff hairs on its feet and tail improve the swimming efficiency of this large, sharply bicoloured shrew, which hunts mainly in water.

7.5–10.5 cm
3–4¼ in

